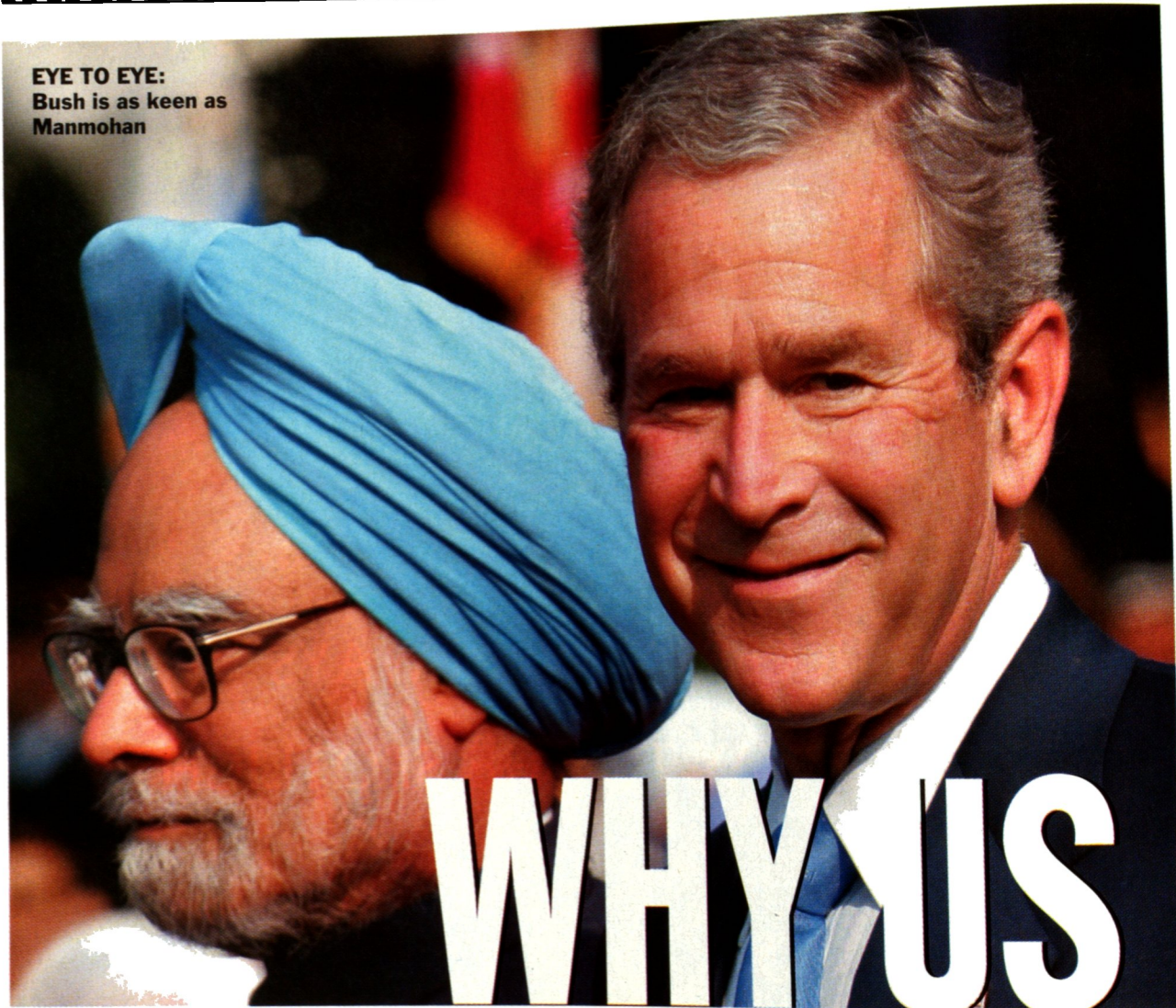


EYE TO EYE:
Bush is as keen as
Manmohan



WHY US

WANTS THE DEAL

■ By Raj Chengappa

So why is the US as keen about moving ahead with the nuclear deal as India is? And just how does the deal benefit America? These are questions that should have been asked much before the debate on the civilian nuclear deal between India and the US turned acrimonious and divisive. In fact, it should have been asked when US President George Bush and India's Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had first announced the path-breaking nuclear initiative in Washington DC on July 18, 2005. However, much of the debate has centred around the real benefits that would accrue to India.

Strange as it may seem, questions are being raised only now, about why the Bush administration is so keen on the deal that it is even willing to stoop to conquer. Especially in recent weeks,

While big business is a major driving force, George Bush has an evangelical belief that with the nuclear hurdle out of the way, India could emerge as a countervailing force to China. Hence the hardsell.

with US officials hardselling the deal to political parties in India that oppose it. BJP is clear: the deal is America's grand ploy to cap India's nuclear weapons programme and reduce its strategic autonomy. The party, though, has not convincingly explained why, if this was America's true objective, did the NDA government initiate the process that led to such a deal. The Left parties, which almost brought the Manmohan Singh Government down by their last-minute opposition to the deal, oppose US objectives on ideological grounds. For them, it is simply "American

imperialism" at work.

In the US, though, the answers are vastly different. Ask Ron Somers, the energetic president of the Washington-based US India Business Council, about what the benefits for America are and he deflects the question almost by reflex. "This is not just an Indo-US deal, this is a global deal. This is about India opening up to the entire world in terms of its nuclear opportunities."

Pressed further, Somers comes to the point: "This is also about removing the cinder from the eye of the Indo-US relationship—that nagging issue of